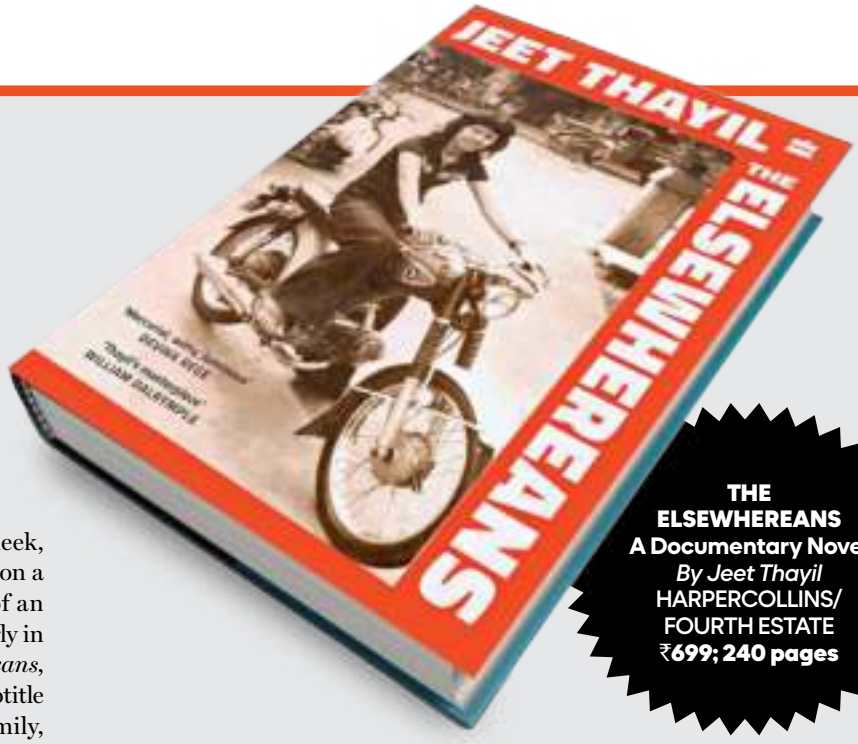


THE ELSEWHEREANS
A Documentary Novel
By Jeet Thayil
HARPERCOLLINS/ FOURTH ESTATE
₹699; 240 pages

At 65, Jeet Thayil remains a sleek, honed physical presence, even on a Zoom call, as befits the son of an athlete. It's a detail we learn early in Thayil's new book *The Elsewhereans*, a 'documentary novel' as the subtitle says, a quasi-memoir about family, belonging and, above all, love.

I received the book in the week that home minister Amit Shah made now-standard remarks about English, about the "mentality of slavery" that afflicts those who insist on speaking it as if to abjure their so-called mother tongue. Thayil reminds me that he wrote a poem decades ago with the line "our mother tongue is not our mother's tongue". That we still remain so conflicted, so unable to claim English, and the varying ways it is spoken and written in India, as a native language is embarrassing.

Thayil's novels, poetry and music, for example, could only ever be written by an Indian writer, even as they're written in a 'global' language—the product of a mind shaped by India's particular postcolonial, and for that matter precolonial, history. "We're in a stage of our national evolution," Thayil says, "where we all feel like outsiders." In a city like Delhi, "dislocation", he adds, "is location". It's an embrace, as is the story told in *The Elsewhereans*, of uncertainty, of travel as a means of finding not just oneself, but others.

In this case, it is the writer using art and language to locate himself as the son of his parents, a life spent, he says, being a "bad son", that has come full circle. It's intriguing that the principal concern of a book that whips us through Hanoi, Hong Kong and Harrisburg is home—how we find it in people, how it can be made and remade wherever we, to quote Thayil (and Paul Young), lay our hat.

The Elsewhereans is a bit like the work of W.G. Sebald and Teju Cole, in its use of photographs as a narrative device, a gesture at verisimilitude even as we understand this is a novel, an act of imaginative rather

BOOKS ▶

RETRACING THE MAP

Sam Dalrymple's *Shattered Lands* is about the end of the British Empire in Asia and the many partitions it left in its wake

SHATTERED LANDS
Five Partitions and the Making of Modern Asia
By Sam Dalrymple
HARPERCOLLINS/ FOURTH ESTATE
₹799; 536 pages

The one thing predictable about empires is that they do fall, and usually there is a messy outcome. It was no different with the British Raj—as countries struggled for their own independence and identity. And sometimes it was the mandarins in Whitehall who just gave up, especially after the second World War. In India, of course, we take pride that we made the British quit the jewel in their crown. But it also meant paying the terrible price of Partition.

Covering a wide swathe of information—some known and some unknown—and written in an energetic, lively style, Sam Dalrymple's *Shattered Lands* reveals and analyses the dismemberment of the British Raj that created the map of modern Asia. This is a riveting account as one scoots across states and countries while Sam mines out nuggets—because, of course, some of the Partitions he speaks about deserve (and have had) complete books written about them. Sam, as a young historian, therefore, brings a perspective that speaks to the present generation who probably do not know that India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Burma, Nepal, Bhutan, Yemen, Oman, UAE, Qatar,